

Nationalistic “official” history can endanger India’s unique memories

A five part series of articles that argues that India is at a critical juncture as the nation has given a mandate to a nationalistic political party. Is this good news for India’s hitherto unbroken memories? Parag Tope (author of Operation Red Lotus) and Jayakrishnan Nair (author of [varnam](#), a blog on history, and a regular contributor to [Pragati](#)) argue that the opportunity is laden with risks, which if left unaddressed, could have disastrous results for the forever nation.

Compared to all the ancient civilizations, India is the only place where there is an unbroken continuity between the land, the people and their stories that have been narrated across the generations. Therefore techniques used for studying dead civilizations are unsuitable for studying a living civilization like India. In this series, we bring out aspects of India which require a new lens for understanding its essence. We also analyze why India needs its own intellectual framework, a new set of semantics and a new frame of reference.

Since the new government has an absolute majority, several voices are calling to replace the British and Marxist influenced “official” history, by ones with a nationalistic outlook and to replace the heads of the central institutions with ones who align with a nationalist ideology.

In the first part, we differentiate between India’s *integral* history and *discrete* histories of other civilizations. India’s enduring history represents the memories of a forever nation, where stories of an ancient river, which disappeared several thousand years ago, is still preserved in folk song, where the location of a sacred city was accurately preserved in religious texts which are used even today.

In part two, we look at the politics of historiography and analyze why this approach is dangerous, especially for India. In the third part, we differentiate between *percipient* and *petrified* histories, and how Indian society --- and not the rulers --- preserved memory of the culture by discarding materialistic markers and focussing on civility. In part four we look at how this has enabled India to preserve important lessons from history without flagellation. India’s unique way of recording history ensured that the lessons from the past were preserved to prevent the same mistakes from being made again without fingerpointing.

In the final and fifth part in this series makes some general and some specific recommendations for the government of India to let Indian society preserve their own history.

Part 1: Enduring history of a forever nation

In the late 1860s, a German businessman, enthusiastic about Greek history, started digging in the small town of Hisarlik in Turkey, in search of a Homeric site. He discovered Troy, made famous in Homer's Iliad with the story of the Trojan horse. There was much debate and excitement among anthropologists and enthusiasts, and when the dust settled, the conclusion was that the site was indeed Troy. This discovery was significant because neither the locals nor any annals had maintained the linkage between Troy and Hisarlik through the centuries. The link was broken as Turkey went through many cultural and political transformations: Greek ethos gave way to the Roman civilization which was then replaced by the Byzantines. The Persians, the Arabs and the Ottomans who followed them, erased ancient memories, replacing it with new ones chosen by the new rulers and the new religions.

Contrast this with a similar archaeological discovery made during our times. In the 1990s, a team of Indian and Italian archaeologists conducted excavations near a village in Farrukhabad district of Uttar Pradesh. Excavations just outside the village led to the discovery of the ancient town of Kampilya, the capital of King Drupada from the Mahabharata. However, this discovery generated neither any debates nor any significant discussions, and the excitement was limited to the archaeological circles.

What can explain the absence of excitement for a seemingly similar discovery? Are Indians not interested in their own past? Is it because it wasn't a businessman who had sponsored the excavation of Kampilya? Or is there another explanation?

The answer is simple: Kampilya, unlike Troy, was never lost and its excavation was never a discovery. For the locals, the mound was always known as *Drupad kila* (Drupad's fort). Although the fort had been buried for thousands of years, knowledge about the fort was transmitted over generations without a break. Also, not surprisingly, the name of the village was Kampil (a variant of Kampilya).

Unlike Turkey, where no local stories had survived the two and half millennia since the legend of Troy, the villagers in Kampil in their own history of at least five thousand years, not only knew about Kampilya, but also about Drupad, his daughter Draupadi and the battles fought near their village. Drupad's story was neither legend, nor Kampilya legendary; they existed as real places with stories that have lasted hundreds of generations.

The absence of excitement in India about ancient discoveries is not surprising, because India is a unique civilization with ancient memories that remain alive. In fact, India is the only place where there is an unbroken continuity between the land, the people and their stories that have been narrated across the generations. Consider other ancient civilizations west of India. Egypt, Rome, Greece, Iran and Mesopotamia still exist, but they are not the same places with which whom India traded during ancient times.

In Egypt, it was the archaeological discoveries during and following the Napoleonic invasion that actually connected Egyptians to their forgotten past. For Greeks, the Minoan, Mycenaean and Hellenistic Greece are all relics of the past and modern day Greeks don't live by the same religion or follow the same culture.

Towards the east, in the case of China, Buddhism became a cultural force that dramatically altered the fabric of the society from the traditions of the Xia, Shang and the Zhou dynasties. Various pre-Buddhist ideologies that dominated the society were replaced by new concepts of *dharma* and *karma*. From 200 BCE and over the next millennium, Buddhism became a powerful force; stories of Buddha in various forms pervaded the society. Shaolin's foundation by Indian monks and the subsequent role that institution played in Chinese political balance further entrenched Buddhist thought into China's political discourse.

The Jewish people have a long memory as well. However, their cultural continuity was detached from their land as the Jews were forced to disperse into various parts of the world.. The geography that encompasses modern day Israel and its neighbours went through several social and political changes similar to those witnessed by Mesopotamia, Turkey and other ancient civilizations in that area.

The pre-European inhabitants of North-America and Australia also maintained a long memory of their civilization. However, the near genocidal attack on their existence by the Europeans all but vanquished many of the tribes. Those who survived are attempting to resurrect and piece back their memories. The memories of peoples of South-America and Africa were also erased as foreign political forces brought the full force of their religious dogmas and replaced the original memories with those considered holy in their respective books.

When it comes to India, Kampil is not the only case where memory was preserved over a long period of time. The memory of the Vedic Saraswati was preserved in local folks songs, Rig Veda and the Mahabharata. Once upon a time Vega or Abhijit was given the status as one of the 27 *nakshatras* (a special star along the ecliptic used for tracking planetary and solar motion). The memory of that becoming the pole star, 13, 000 years ago, is known to Indians even today. The ratio 5:4 was commonly by the people of the Indus-Saraswati civilization for constructing cities, by the Vedic people for building fire altars, by Varahamihira for building palaces, by the artisans who built the Delhi Iron pillar and is used even now by the Jaipur Royal family in their flag, which is a continuity of about five millennia.

In the 19th century, much before the arrival of modern archaeology, the people of Ujjain knew that their city was built on top of another ancient city and for building a house, they could get well baked bricks just by digging around. Based on the description in *Skanda Purana* that Dwaraka, which was known as Kusasthali, was situated at the confluence of Gomati and the Western Sea, the Archaeological Survey of India conducted twelve seasons of marine archaeology in the area. This yielded Harappan pottery, Indus seals and epigraphs and based on that the lead archaeologist suggested a 17th - 18th century BCE date for the site.

Indians have always known about India's uniqueness vis-a-vis other ancient civilizations. Allama Iqbal expressed these exact thoughts when he wrote:

युनानो-मिस्रो-रोमा सब् मिट गये जहांसे
अब तक मगर है बाकि नामो निशां हमारा
कुछ बात है कि हस्ति मिटती नहीं हमारी...

Greek, Roman and Egyptian civilizations have all vanished without a trace
Yet, our identity remains unbroken
There is something unique about us, that preserves our existence...

Indian history, with its unbroken continuity has integrated the memories of the past into stories that remain live even today. Other civilizations with discrete periods of existence are visible to us through annals and records that appear in discrete forms and periods. Therefore, we can describe Indic history to be an "integral" history, akin to the mathematical concept of integration over time, versus other civilizations that have maintained "discrete" histories. This key differentiator between India and other civilizations is important to consider as India attempts to reassess its own history.

Although that is an important differentiator, there are other aspects as well which makes India unique. While the ancient civilizations are dead and the techniques used for understanding them are similar to a post-mortem, they cannot be used for understanding a living civilization. Indian society had the ability to perceive, discern, discriminate and select what is remembered for posterity,

Today, a nationalistic government is leading India and several voices are calling to replace the current "official" history that is out of touch with India, with one with a nationalistic outlook and to replace the heads of the central institutions with ones who align with a nationalist ideology. Though this reactionary approach seems the right way to undo the damage done by the previous culprits, this could be dangerous for India. In the next part, we look at the politics of "official" history and in the subsequent parts we explain India's unique style of historiography.

Part 2: India and the politics of “official” history

Politics of Historiography

European polity has dominated modern discourse in recent times, and it is represented in their hierarchical top-down systems that come in various flavors. Whether they are an “acy”, an “ism”, or an “ity” – they all have one thing in common: they all view society either as errant or as sheep, which needs to be controlled and shepherded. What differentiates various systems from each other is the extent of shepherding and whether the shepherds emerge from the sheep. This also has translated into academic institutions and government machinery following these models in areas that attempt to wield control over society.

Western Historiography is based on theoretical frameworks, such as marxism, nationalism, post-colonialism, post-modernism, or feminism and draws from social sciences, religion and anthropology and more. These frameworks provide a specific perspective and the conclusion reached by historians depends on which of these colored lenses they are wearing. Historiography has been used as tools towards shepherding the masses and follows a consistent two step pattern. First, “eminent” people with certificates of qualifications and specialized degrees are given charge of influential institutions in their humanities departments. They control the intellectual framework for history and anthropology as well as the narratives that are created based on that framework. Well funded large universities and institutions author authoritative volumes which are then condensed and simplified for various educational levels. Next, the government controlled educational system works as a distribution channel for students who are nothing more than consumers of ideas created by these “highly qualified and intellectually superior” people.

This is in complete contrast to India’s ethos where society determines qualifications of individuals based on their observed day to day actions. Personal sacrifice of material gain and power, towards the pursuit of knowledge, was given the highest respect; not degrees and certificates from highly funded institutions. Further, the responsibility of propagating memories remained with society and was never outsourced to any authority or central institution, regardless of their qualifications, stature or intelligence. India’s long held memories helped Indians recognize the patterns of oppression inflicted by the British and they fought against Britain relentlessly. The part success achieved in the Anglo-Indian war of 1857 was a result of Indian memories that equipped Indian society to support Indian leaders and form alliances and challenge the oppressive economic, political and social systems imposed by the British. The Azamgarh proclamation of August 1857, which demanded political, economic and personal freedom, was an acknowledgement of this unbroken Indian ethos.

To neutralize India’s decentralized memories, the British launched a two pronged attack. First, they created centralized institutional structures, and second, used those institutions to launch an ideological assault and propaganda against Indic ethos. They hired consultants to write Indian history with an anti-Indic bias through various narratives. The mission of these pen wielding

mercenaries was to eventually replace India's unique memories with "official history."

The techniques for erasing memories were perfected within the Western world. As Christianity spread, Pagan cultures were erased, Orwellian memory holes were created to incinerate inconvenient remnants of past history to prevent any resurgence of those who were vanquished. Sometimes the incineration was physical, with the near successful genocide in the "New World", where "Guns, Germs and Steel", were used to wipe out native people and their memories. A less dramatic, but effective example of a memory hole is renaming a place, a person or an object to delink from the past.

Fortunately, the two pronged assault on India was not entirely successful. Indian society viewed the English rule and any institution that attempted to influence society with skepticism. With the exception of a small section of the English influenced minority, Indians largely ignored centralized propaganda that passed off as history.

But, this changed after the English were evicted. India had the opportunity to neutralize both the assaults by dismantling the centralized institutions as well as end the propaganda perpetuated against Indic ethos.

Independent India's leaders did neither.

Missed Opportunities

The centralized institutions not only remained intact, they were strengthened. In the 1950s, "pseudo-nationalists" and "marxists" battled to control these centralized institutions. Both sides claimed that their attempt to "rewrite" history was from an Indian perspective, yet neither had any intention of doing so. The "pseudo-nationalists" wore anti-Islamic lenses, and offered no insight into Indic ethos, other than creating a supposedly nationalistic narrative that had little correlation with Indian memories. On the other hand, the "marxists" were defined by their anti-capitalist and anti-imperialist lenses offering an imagined narrative consistent with their ideological preferences and a strong anti-Indic bias. Neither of the two warring sides really understood India and its eternal memories, or worse, deliberately chose to misrepresent India.

The Marxists won this battle and exercised complete control over education, academia and humanities. The only change Independence bought was that English propaganda was replaced by Marxist propaganda, using the old and newly formed institutions created with the same intent.

They successfully labelled themselves as "historians" (without the Marxist tag), or "liberals with a scientific outlook" while anyone questioning them were slandered as "communal." They continued the attack on the section of society which was critical in preserving memories through stories and philosophical treatises, and blamed them for all the ills in society. They considered it their burden to fix the flaws of an errant Indian society through power and manipulation. They hoisted Western historians who highlighted the negativity that had befallen India's social fabric during India's

economic destruction under English misrule. Holding on to the past was considered “orthodoxy” and forgetting it, “progress.”

Indian society was more receptive to the propaganda produced by these post-independence institutions because they believed that they were run by “well meaning and progressive” Indians. These “historians” either lacked an understanding of Indic ethos or deliberately chose to misunderstand it. They used centralized institutions to propagate ideas learned from their peers in other parts of the world. For them everything was a class struggle and this thesis had to be accepted for one to be considered as “secular.”

Despite this propaganda, Indian society and families continued to practice traditional pursuits and maintain a culture that implicitly represented the unbroken narrative of India. Over time Indians society continued to reject what was taught in classrooms because it had little correlation with the culture that they lived in. This skepticism prevented the centralized monolithic machinery from gaining wide acceptance in Indian society – thus continuing to shield India’s ethos of decentralized history.

Today, India is at a crossroads again.

From अध्यात्मिक Participants to Bystanders and Consumers

A nationalistic Indian government is leading India, which wears an unabashedly pro-Indian lens rather than the jaundiced lenses worn by the “pseudo-nationalists” and the “marxists.” This nationalistic government now controls these centralized institutions created by the English and then expanded by the Marxists. Is this situation good for Indic ethos? Contrary to what most nationalists believe, the situation has the potential to be disastrous. In fact far more disastrous than the Marxist takeover of these institutions.

The reason is that a majority of Indians in society, who thus far have viewed both the British and Marxists with suspicion, might let their guard down and accept centralized and nationalistic versions of Indian history that might be written from an Indian point of view. For them, a rewriting of Indian history with a nationalist viewpoint would be the perfect way to undo the damage cause thus far.

What they don’t see is that the fundamental flaw in India’s post-Independent approach to history was not about *who* would control these institutions. The flaw was that these centralized monolithic institutions continued to exist for someone to control, as a proposed *replacement* for India’s decentralized memories. It is not the narrative, with or without the biases, that is the primary threat to India’s memories, but the mere existence of any official narrative, that is accepted by society, that will pose as the biggest threat to India’s decentralized history.

Indian society today, despite the educational system, has remained active in transmitting past memories. However, if the Indian government offers a curriculum in history that the society finds

acceptable, then the society will transform itself from proponents and champions of history to *consumers* of history. Society will become a mere bystander as “better qualified people with degrees and certificates,” combined with a “nationalistic outlook” take control over what always belonged to the people.

India's ethos is driven by the engine of diversity and powered by the principles of अध्यात्म (*adhyatma*). *Adhyatma*, roughly translates as “the supreme self,” where the self is considered to be the prime mover as each person takes responsibility for themselves and builds a self-reliant society. Whether India embraces a “unifying” consumer culture in *materialistic* pursuits is a separate discussion. The immediate question is will India embrace a consumer culture in history and philosophy? As a society that respects the notion of अध्यात्म, India's core strength is her ability to thrive *intellectually*, at the level of each individual, without external authority and *despite* the government – be it oppressive or *friendly*. No oppressive ruler has been able to take that away from her. Will a friendly government succeed in dismantling India's decentralized ethos, where all enemies have failed?

Of all the threats that Indian memories have faced – the threat of a successful implementation and acceptance of centralized history is the gravest. What the Mughals could not even dent, where Macaulay and Bentinck mostly failed, and where Marxist controlled institutions could only find limited success in hurting India's ethos – will a nationalistic government unintentionally succeed in destroying it? Will it become an agent of destruction of the Indian nation's core values preserved in India's decentralized, dispersive and percipient history?

The answer depends on the choices that are made today. Never has India in the recent past faced this dilemma. India's society has finally handed a mandate to nationalistic Indians, which gives the leaders the key to the *hallowed* halls of institutions considered esteemed by hierarchical power structures around the world. With those keys in hand, Indians can finally rewrite the history of India from a nationalistic perspective, which so far has been written by its enemies. Yet, by choosing to do so will hurt India more than what the enemies of India's civilization could ever do.

What next?

If rewriting Indian history from a nationalistic perspective is dangerous – what is the alternative?

To make recommendations, it is important to take a step back, analyze and to create a new framework for the understanding of how Indians have preserved their memories successfully. The following two parts attempt to create a new framework for analysis of India's history and presents an alternative model and semantics that is consistent with India's ethos. The fifth and final part in this series makes some general and some specific recommendations for the government of India to mitigate the risks that India's eternal memories face.

In the next part we will introduce the concept of *percipient* history and contrast it with the *petrified*

history of other ancient civilizations.

Part 3: From Petrified History to Percipient History

In the first part of this series we described India as having an “integral” history versus other civilizations having maintained “discrete” histories. This key differentiator between India and other civilizations is an important factor to consider as India attempts to reassess its own history. For example, various western anthropological models of civilizations describe several phases of a civilization. They typically start with some description of a beginning and some description of a decay and then an ending.

India does not share that experience, because all ancient civilizations, with the exception of India, are akin to fallen trees petrified over the centuries. Petrification is a process that replaces the live cells of a tree with minerals that fossilize the cells and preserve the structure. Archaeological findings of ancient civilizations are in many ways similar to finding a petrified tree. Unlike a live tree, a petrified tree can be sliced and its rings counted to know how old the tree was when it died. A petrified tree also preserves the signature of the minerals that it absorbs when they replace the live cells providing critical information about the period of petrification; a dead civilization provides answers that offer as much clarity as a petrified tree does.

However, India is a living civilization, which has preserved the memory of ancient times across generations through the memory of people, stories and philosophical treatises. India’s unbroken continuity means that it is an ancient, but a live tree, like a banyan tree that has roots spread far and wide. Can a live Banyan tree answer a simple question as to how old it is? Can it even answer the question as to where the original trunk was? Perhaps, only if parts of the tree were petrified, like the sites near Saraswati and Kampil.

Absence of fossilized anthropological evidence does not indicate the absence of antiquity. The methodologies that are applied to study what died and preserved, have to differ from methodologies that are required to study a live civilization. To find out what a person ate before he died, one can perform an autopsy and examine the contents of the stomach. What about a live person? Well – just ask what they ate. Therefore, studying Indian history needs a fundamentally new approach which has to be different from the study of dead fossilized civilizations. It needs to be analogous to asking a live civilization “what do you remember?”

For example, if you ask the Rajasthanis on why their region is a desert, they would tell us that it is due to the disappearance of a mighty river which had once flowed through the region. Even though the river vanished more than four millennia back, the memory is preserved in folk songs and local traditions where the king does a puja to calm down Saraswati. If you had asked the people of Kampil, even before excavating, they would have told you that the mound in their village actually hid a fort. Much before satellite imagery found the paleo channels, Indians who had read the *nadistuti sukta* of the Rigveda would have told you that the location of Saraswati was between Yamuna and Sutlej.

India's secret of this contiguous memory lies in the ability of the society to retell the stories across generations. The carriers of these memories were not political rulers, but society itself. These memories were carried across generations through folk songs, dances, stories and enactments of epics. This is very different from the concept of annals, or what is known as recorded or "official" history of events recorded by courts of kings. Thus, preservation of history in India was highly decentralized, yet, the themes of preservation were common.

Though India has a unique combination of diversity of language and culture, Indians are bound by a common thread of stories and traditions. Society achieved this by maintaining a section of the population who took the responsibility of religious activities, as well as educating themselves in a broad category of subjects, that included stories and philosophical treatises. Additionally, pilgrimages to various "तीर्थस्थल" was encouraged by ensuring that the lodging and boarding was free of cost. In return the guests would perform ceremonies, religious activities, hold philosophical discussions, perform vedic recitations, and discuss stories and philosophies with their hosts which allowed for a cross-pollination of not only ideas, concepts, and philosophies, but also stories, best practices and the opportunity for selecting and sharing stories.

Just as a historian makes editorial selections in what goes in a history book, society, in combination with a culture that encouraged cross-pollination of ideas, made similar choices. What makes one story more important than other? Why preserve the memory of one event and not another?

Just as प्रकृति (prakriti) represents impermanent, changing and evolving ideas, संस्कृति (Sanskriti) defines सनातन (Sanatana - everlasting or immutable) ideas. Editorial selections were made based on what concepts were considered प्राकृतिक (Prakritic or impermanent) and what concepts were considered सांस्कृतिक (Sanskritic or immutable). If an event significantly affected the lives of people and the lessons learned were considered immutable, it got added to the stories worthy of preservation.

This automatically meant that western notion of civilization, based on materialistic markers, were generally ignored in an Indian ethos. Indians placed सभ्यता or civility above materialistic markers of civilization. This relative prioritization allowed Indians to identify stories that were worth preserving, without getting seduced by materialistic markers. This is exemplified in the story of Ram's life, where the seeming prosperity of Ravana's Lanka, with its multi-storied palaces and bejewelled and gold decor, are described in great detail. Yet, Ayodhya which had far less impressive materialistic markers in comparison to Lanka, was considered superior, because of the civility that existed in society that was free from Ravana's oppressive regime.

These stories not only provided the audience with the tools to recognize what was worthy of cherishing, it also put a spotlight on the important concept that if power was centralized in the hands of oppressive regimes, civility would break down. This acknowledgment that civility had broken down in the past in cyclical patterns, equipped Indians to look to their history for lessons that would enable them to overcome the obstacles.

With society's ability to perceive, discern, discriminate and select what is remembered for posterity, Indic memories can therefore be best described as *Percipient History*. Percipient history depends on the preservation of what the society perceives is worthy of preservation. Petrified history is more about preservation of snapshots of discrete periods of history, which includes "historical records." The process of keeping records was often undertaken by rulers, administrators and therefore represented the view of the state or institutions and not society. The concept of centralized study of Petrified history was forced upon India by the English. This was then propagated by historians who continued to be seduced by the beauty of material markers preserved as petrified civilizations, rather than the wisdom and perceptiveness of a living civilization.

As India reassesses history, it needs to make a distinction between non-Indic petrified history and India's percipient history. Indians also need to look at the unique style of Indian historiography which was to extract empowering lessons which would benefit future generations without indulging in flagellation. We will look at this in the next part.

Part 4: Empowering history, no flagellation

Whether one evaluates petrified history or percipient history, the practical benefits of studying history are only as relevant to how that knowledge helps the present and the future. Therefore, the study of history must achieve two goals:

- Learn from positives by identifying success – things done right.
- Learn from failures but identifying mistakes – things gone wrong.

Modern (read European/western) history attempts to achieve the same goals, however, these methods are constrained by their own narrow paradigms:

- Institutions, not society, were and remain primarily responsible for “official” history,
- Narratives are based on a linear time-frame, absolute time lines and display an obsession to date everything,
- Materialistic markers and dating are used to competitively rank petrified civilizations.
- A western sense of civility (or an absence thereof) in the identification of “things gone wrong.” This “civility” is on full display in highly flagellating what-if analyses, name calling, character assassinations and finger pointing and form the foundation of historical narratives.

Western methodologies for history are consistent with their polity – where institutions and state dominate over the lives of people. This is not only true today, but was true during Roman and Greek periods as well. Therefore it is not uncommon to find semi-hagiographic records of anyone associated with those institutions forming the basis of “historical records.” For example, we have a good idea about Plato’s lineage, how he got his name and who his siblings were while we have no clue on where Aryabhata was born, who his parents were or who his teachers were.

If the goal is to learn from the positives and avoid repeating mistakes, how do dates and lineage matter? Analytical processes have their place in any intellectual framework, however, when it comes to history – why are absolutes important? The answer becomes clear if one attempts to understand the roots of western ethos, polity and a linear view of time.

Progress versus the कालचक्र (Kaalachakra - wheel of time)

This linearity lends itself to a near obsession with the concept of “progress.” However, this obsession with progress is matched by the equally strong fear of the impending apocalypse. From a western intellectual framework, the past petrification does indeed offer lessons about their own imminent future. Western ethos, rooted in fear of the apocalypse, recognizes that their future could be leading down the path of destruction. Every few decades Europeans and Westerners, both from the “religious right” and the “progressive left” claim that the world is going to end soon, because humans are sinners or polluters.

In that framework, these lessons are indeed relevant and therefore desire introspection. Thus, the

western obsession to date every event is also understandable. If doomsday is coming, would it not make sense to predict when it is coming? Consequently, western methodologies are appropriate to prevent a destruction that their religious texts, or scientific fears, claim is impending.

Western timelines are stratified into various “ages” indicating a certain linear progression. Thus when the English wrote Indian history, it was conveniently split into a Hindu age, Muslim age and a British age. Indian ethos operates differently. Indians never looked upon time as linear, but cyclical and in that context the need to date everything is considered a fools errand.

Similarly, India’s percipient history is primarily about learning from the positives and therefore, Indic memories present a large number of positive role models. The best practices are preserved by recognizing the “things done right” and by identifying those who did the right things and placing them on a pedestal.

Civility and Historical Amnesia

What about mistakes and “things gone wrong”? Indic memories clearly place the heroes of a story on a pedestal – be it Vishnu or Durga in their various Avatars. The antagonists, those who are the cause of the imbalance, driven by ego or ambition to lord over others, like Ravana and other Asuras, are explicitly assailed. However, Indic memories display a selective amnesia of the names of all those who either blundered, betrayed, or made bad choices, which enabled the antagonists to become powerful in the first place. Surely the rise of Ravana must have been at the cost of several kings making strategic blunders, being bribed, bought or beaten.

Indic civility or सभ्यता clearly discourages finger pointing or flagellation. This easily explains why Indic memories are amnesic when it comes to offering lessons learned that involve any sort of finger pointing at any historical person, persons or even citizens who might have made mistakes that led to further failures.

If stories of defeat were editorially eliminated, because civility could not accommodate finger pointing, how did Indians learn from their mistakes? Is Indic civility or सभ्यता a curse that prevents Indians from truly learning from failures? Were ancient Indians in their desire to be civil, fail to preserve the lessons learned for posterity?

There are two possibilities:

1. Yes – the absence of finger pointing does indeed indicate that Indic memories fail in providing the lessons learned for later generations.
2. No – Ancient Indians were able to solve the problem and overcome the “constraint of civility” by preserving the lessons learned without pointing fingers.

Those who are stuck in a linear, apocalypse fearing, western mindset, would argue that the answer is 1 above.

Consider the other possibility. Is it possible to separate the lessons learned from the primary story and the characters who blundered? Is naming the individual who blundered, important from learning from their mistakes?

Dispersive History

The answer is Dispersive History – where events of relevance, like light passing through a prism, are filtered through a prism of Indic ethos and “dispersed” into relevant buckets for consumption by generations to come.

Dispersive history splits important events four ways:

1. The protagonists are named and are placed on a pedestal.
2. The antagonists are named and denounced.
3. Mala fide actions, that remain a part of human failings that include corruption and betrayal, offer no new lessons. Those who might have been bought or betrayed are ignored and their names forgotten with time.
4. Bona fide mistakes are encapsulated as lessons learned in abstracted form. The names and sometimes even the species are changed to avoid direct finger pointing. This is history with pseudonymous characters which can be described as *abstracted pseudonymous history*.

The stories in हितोपदेश (Hitopadesha – good advice), the पंचतन्त्र (Panchatantras – five principles) or the philosophical observations made in poetic form in the सुभाषित (subhashitas – “well said” ideas) – are abstracted observations with pseudonymous characters, that were likely to have been inspired from real events. The names or the specifics in the stories are far less relevant than the lessons themselves.

For example, a king who was seduced by rhetoric and ignored obvious red flags in an alliance, could have easily inspired the story told in the हितोपदेश (good advice) of the “old tiger and the greedy traveler”. Or citizens of a country that were seduced by free handouts of a seemingly benign, but oppressive ruler, could have inspired the story of the “doves”. the hunter, the grains of rice, and a mouse.” The story of how a weak, but clever king who used the power of an ally to defeat an enemy could have formed the basis for the panchatantra story काकस्य उपायः (*kaakasya Upaayah* – A Crow’s Solution)

Furthermore, children were exposed to these stories early in life – so that they could grow up with these lessons. As adults, they could recognize the traps that their ancestors might have fallen into – and learn to avoid them. This helped achieve the second goal of historical analysis, without any flagellation or sacrificing the civility that defines Indic ethos.

This way of preserving stories for posterity is another distinctive feature of India. These stories were important in the lessons they taught, but simple enough that it was both entertaining and could be communicated easily irrespective of the age and educational background of their listeners. Some of these stories were even simplified into common sayings which are used in

everyday conversations even today.

How do you use this understanding of Indian historiography to alter the way history was written in India? In the final part of this series, we offer some suggestions.
